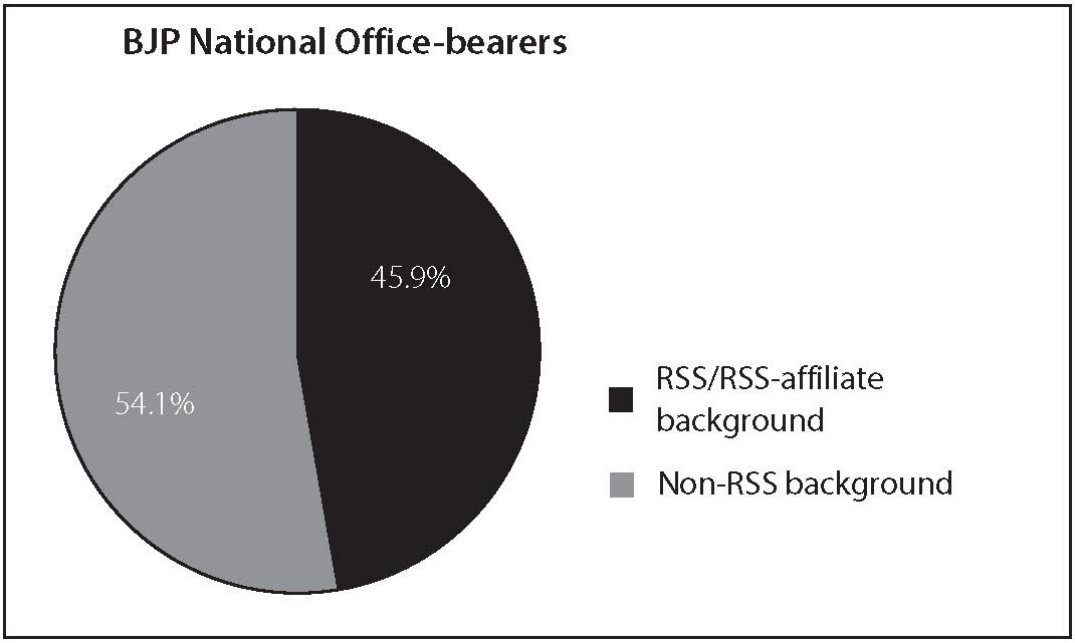


Source: Author's fieldwork, with research support from Rajiv Pundir. Data is accurate as of 24 September 2020. Note: We did not count the Parliamentary Board or Central Election Committee since many office-bearers overlapped with these bodies.

Make no mistake, the Modi government and the BJP are not controlled by the RSS, but the RSS has a higher imprint on both than it did when Vajpayee was prime minister. Under Modi, the BJP is happy to proclaim its RSS links. Many of its ministers are deeply driven by RSS thinking and its cultural agenda. A separate Ministry of Animal Husbandry, Dairy and Fisheries was created in 2019, following a suggestion that is said to have chiefly emerged from the VHP. The National Education Policy (NEP) also listed several suggestions in the draft policy from Sangh-affiliated organisations.[55]

A step below the Centre, a similar pattern of representation is replicated in BJP-ruled states. We examined the Shivraj Singh Chouhan-led BJP government of Madhya Pradesh between 2013 and 2020. We came across an interesting contrast between the Chouhan government that was in power in 2013–2018 and the government he formed on 24 March 2020, after twenty-three Congress MLAs defected to the BJP, along with senior leader Jyotiraditya Scindia, to bring down the Kamal Nath-led government that had come to power in December 2018. The earlier Chouhan cabinet had only twenty cabinet ministers and 40 per cent of them